PassFrame
TUITION

The Secret Life of Bees

Year 4 — 11+ Homework Worksheet (PassFrame Tuition)

Comprehension | Non-fiction (Nature)

Extract — read it carefully before answering

Inside every beehive lives a tiny, tireless community of thousands of bees, each one working for the good of the whole hive rather than for itself. At the centre of it all is the queen bee, the only bee able to lay eggs, who can produce up to 2,000 eggs in a single day.

Worker bees — all of them female — spend their short lives on an extraordinary variety of jobs. Some clean and guard the hive, some care for the young, and others fly out to collect nectar and pollen from flowers, sometimes travelling over eight kilometres in a single journey.

Perhaps the most astonishing thing about bees is how they communicate. When a worker bee discovers a good source of flowers, she returns to the hive and performs a special movement called the waggle dance, wiggling her body in a particular pattern to tell the other bees exactly where the flowers are and how far away they lie.

As bees travel from flower to flower collecting nectar, tiny grains of pollen stick to the hairs on their legs and bodies. Without realising it, the bees carry this pollen from one flower to the next, allowing plants to produce seeds and fruit — a process called pollination that much of our food supply depends upon.

Scientists estimate that roughly one in every three mouthfuls of food we eat exists only because of pollinators like bees. Without these small, hardworking insects, our fields, orchards and gardens would look very different indeed.

Questions

25 min · 12 questions

1. What is the only job the queen bee can do that other bees cannot?

2. What two things do bees collect from flowers?

3. Underline the sentence that tells you worker bees are all female.

4. Underline the sentence that describes how far a worker bee might fly on one trip.

5. What does “tireless” suggest about how the bees work?

6. Put these events in order: pollen sticks to the bee's legs / a bee performs the waggle dance / a worker bee finds flowers / a plant produces seeds and fruit.

7. Why might the author describe the beehive as a “community” rather than just a group of insects?

8. What word is used to describe the process of carrying pollen between flowers?

9. Why do you think scientists have studied the waggle dance so closely?

10. What does the comparison to “one in every three mouthfuls” of food tell you about the scale of bees' importance?

11. Find and copy a word that means “amazing” or “very surprising”.

12. Write one or two sentences explaining what you think might happen to our food supply if bees disappeared.